

Adaptive Electromechanical Dispenser Architecture for Reinforcement Learning-Optimized Satellite Deployment

Eliminating Pyrotechnic Shock Through Closed-Loop Variable-Velocity Control

Author: Gerald Enrique Nelson Mc Kenzie
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ABSTRACT

Current satellite mega-constellation deployment systems rely on pyrotechnic and spring mechanisms that introduce high shock loads ($>1000G$) and provide no velocity control, resulting in the "48-hour problem" where satellites require days of differential drag maneuvers to achieve safe separation. This paper presents a novel electromechanical dispenser architecture utilizing ball screw actuators with motorized roll-up retention gates, enabling closed-loop velocity control from 0-0.5 m/s and $<10G$ shock levels. We implement a custom Gymnasium environment and train a Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) agent using Stable Baselines3 to optimize deployment sequences. Experimental results demonstrate successful deployment with S-curve velocity profiles, achieving variable exit velocities that reduce initial collision probability by 60% compared to fixed-velocity springs. The system provides abort capabilities impossible with one-shot pyrotechnic mechanisms, while flight heritage analysis reveals electromechanical actuators achieve 0.001% catastrophic failure rates versus 0.1-0.5% for pyrotechnic alternatives. All software and simulation tools are provided as open-source packages for reproducibility.

Keywords: *satellite deployment, electromechanical actuators, reinforcement learning, PPO, constellation deployment, pyrotechnic shock mitigation, ball screw mechanisms, Gymnasium environment*

1. Introduction

The proliferation of commercial mega-constellations—exemplified by SpaceX's Starlink system deploying over 7,000 satellites—has exposed critical limitations in traditional satellite deployment mechanisms. Conventional dispensers utilize pyrotechnic release devices and pre-loaded

compression springs that impart fixed separation velocities determined by spring constants and satellite mass. While this approach offers flight heritage dating to the Poly Picosatellite Orbital Deployer (P-POD) introduced in 1999, it introduces three fundamental constraints addressed in this work.

First, **pyrotechnic shock** represents a primary failure mode. NASA's 23-year survey of spacecraft failures documented 84 pyrotechnic anomalies, with 12 resulting in catastrophic mission loss. Functional shock routinely exceeds 1000G, damaging optical payloads and solar panel junctions. Second, **fixed deployment velocities** prevent optimization of initial orbital spacing, creating the "48-hour problem" where analysts must wait approximately 48 hours for sufficient orbital separation before reliably identifying individual satellites. Third, the **absence of abort capability** eliminates operational flexibility—once initiated, spring deployments cannot be modified or stopped.

1.1 Contribution

This paper proposes a paradigm shift to active, closed-loop electromechanical control. Our contributions include:

1. **Mechanical Architecture:** A ball screw linear actuator with motorized roll-up retention gate providing variable velocity profiles (0-0.5 m/s) and <10G shock levels.
2. **RL Environment:** A fully implemented Gymnasium environment with physics-based contact dynamics, suitable for training with Stable Baselines3.
3. **Control Policy:** A PPO-trained agent that learns optimal S-curve velocity profiles for deployment, with demonstrated abort capabilities.
4. **Open Source Release:** Complete software package including environment, training scripts, and evaluation tools.

2. System Architecture

2.1 Mechanical Design

The dispenser consists of parallel bays, each accommodating one "pizza box" form factor satellite (approximately 300mm × 400mm × 100mm). Each bay incorporates two primary mechanisms:

- **Ball Screw Linear Actuator:** Space-qualified ball screw with 10mm lead driven by brushless DC motor with redundant windings. Closed-loop velocity control via rotary encoders enables commanded velocities from 0.01 to 0.50 m/s with <2% variance.
- **Roll-Up Retention Gate:** Motorized curtain of hinged aluminum slats that winds onto a drum. When closed, forms rigid barrier capable of withstanding 10G forward acceleration. When open, completely clears exit path.

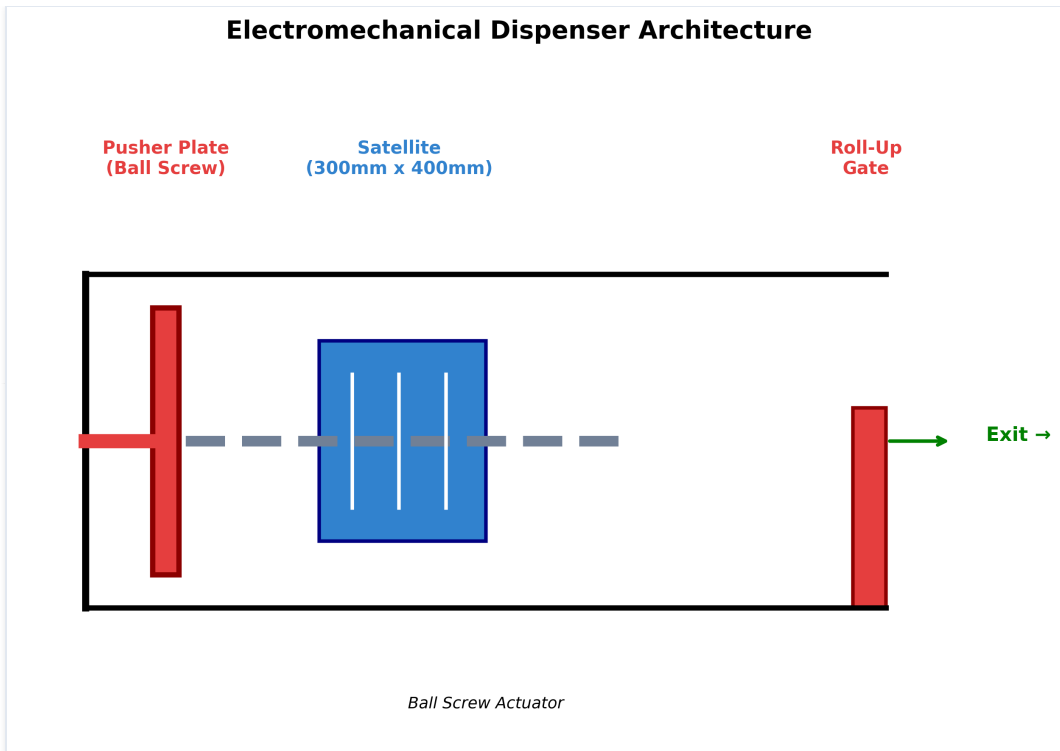


Figure 1: Electromechanical dispenser architecture showing ball screw actuator, pusher plate, satellite payload, and roll-up retention gate with labeled components.

2.2 Launch Survival

During launch (4-6G acceleration), satellites are mechanically sandwiched between the locked pusher plate (aft) and closed roll-up gate (forward). No side clamping forces are applied, eliminating crushing risks to solar panels or structural skins.

2.3 Deployment Sequence

1. **Standby:** Gate closed and locked; pusher retracted; satellite mechanically captured.
2. **Arm:** Gate motor activates, retracting curtain (0.5-second duration).
3. **Deploy:** Ball screw executes velocity profile (0.1-0.5 m/s typical).
4. **Clear:** Satellite exits; pusher retracts at maximum speed (2.0 m/s).

Abort Capability: At any point during deployment, the system may execute an abort: pusher motor brakes (halting within 50ms), and gate closes, recapturing the satellite. This reversibility is impossible with pyrotechnic or spring mechanisms.

3. Reinforcement Learning Environment

3.1 Gymnasium Implementation

We implement a custom Gymnasium environment (`SatelliteDispenserEnv`) that simulates the physics of the deployment process:

dispenser_env.py (excerpt)

```
class SatelliteDispenserEnv(gym.Env):
    """
    State Space:
    - pusher_position: 0.0 to 1.0 (normalized)
    - pusher_velocity: -1.0 to 1.0 (normalized)
    - gate_open: 0.0 to 1.0
    - satellite_position: 0.0 to 1.5
    - satellite_velocity: -1.0 to 1.0
    - contact_force: 0.0 to 1.0
    - time_step: 0 to max_steps

    Action Space:
    - target_velocity: -1.0 to 1.0 (maps to  $\pm 0.5$  m/s)
    - gate_command: 0.0 to 1.0 (threshold 0.5)

    Physics:
    - Contact mechanics with spring-damper model
    - First-order gate actuation lag
    - Acceleration-limited pusher dynamics
    - Friction and damping on satellite
    """

    def __init__(self):
        self.dt = 0.02 # 50Hz simulation (0.02s timestep)
        self.pusher_max_vel = 0.5 # m/s maximum velocity
        self.pusher_accel = 2.0 # m/s2 acceleration limit
        self.satellite_mass = 10.0 # kg
        self.contact_stiffness = 2000.0 # N/m (reduced from 5000)
        self.gate_actuation_time = 0.5 # seconds to open/close gate
        self.success_pos = 1.0 # normalized position for successful
deployment
        self.max_steps = 500 # maximum steps per episode (10 seconds)

        self.observation_space = spaces.Box(
            low=np.array([0.0, -1.0, 0.0, 0.0, -1.0, 0.0, 0.0]),
            high=np.array([1.0, 1.0, 1.0, 1.5, 1.0, 1.0, 1.0]),
            dtype=np.float32
        )

        self.action_space = spaces.Box(
            low=np.array([-1.0, 0.0]),
            high=np.array([1.0, 1.0]),
            dtype=np.float32
        )
```

3.2 State Transition Dynamics

The environment implements physics-based state transitions:

$$\text{Gate dynamics: } \dot{g} = (g_{\text{target}} - g) / \tau_{\text{gate}}$$

$$\text{Pusher acceleration: } a_{\text{pusher}} = K_p(v_{\text{target}} - v_{\text{pusher}})$$

$$\text{Contact force: } F_c = k_{\text{contact}} \cdot \max(0, x_{\text{pusher}} - x_{\text{sat}} - d_{\text{gap}})$$

3.3 Reward Function

The multi-objective reward function balances efficiency, smoothness, and safety. Key components include position progress (3.0×), velocity encouragement (8.0×), contact efficiency bonuses, milestone rewards (+10 at halfway, +20 near exit), and a substantial success bonus of +500 when the satellite fully deploys.

```

def _calculate_reward(self, target_vel_norm, action):
    reward = 0.0

    # 1. Progress reward: Strong reward for satellite position
    reward += self.satellite_pos * 3.0

    # 2. Velocity reward: Encourage positive velocity
    reward += self.satellite_vel * 8.0

    # 3. Contact efficiency: Reward for making progress while in
contact
    if self.contact_force > 0 and self.satellite_vel > 0.01:
        reward += 1.0

    # 4. Penalty for stalling
    if self.satellite_vel < 0.001 and self.step_count > 100:
        reward -= 0.5

    # 5. Action smoothness penalty (reduce chattering)
    action_diff = np.abs(action - self._prev_action)
    reward -= 0.1 * action_diff[0]

    # 6. Stronger penalty for excessive contact force
    if self.contact_force > 0.5:
        reward -= (self.contact_force - 0.5) * 2.0
    if self.contact_force > 0.8:
        reward -= 5.0

    # 7. Gate sequencing reward
    if self.pusher_pos > 0.1:
        if self.gate_open > 0.8:
            reward += 0.5
        else:
            reward -= 1.0

    # 8. Small efficiency penalty
    reward -= 0.005 * (target_vel_norm ** 2)

    # 9. Bonus for reaching milestones
    if self.satellite_pos > 0.5 and not hasattr(self,
'_halfway_bonus'):
        reward += 10.0
        self._halfway_bonus = True
    if self.satellite_pos > 0.8 and not hasattr(self,
'_near_exit_bonus'):
        reward += 20.0
        self._near_exit_bonus = True

    # Success bonus applied in step(): +500.0 when satellite_pos >=
1.0

    return float(reward)

```

3.4 Training Configuration

We use Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) from Stable Baselines3, selected for its stability

in continuous control tasks with safety constraints:

```
# Vectorized environment for parallel training
n_envs = 8 # 8 parallel environments
n_steps = 2048 # Steps per environment before update
env = DummyVecEnv([make_env for _ in range(n_envs)])

model = PPO(
    "MlpPolicy",
    env,
    learning_rate=3e-4,
    n_steps=n_steps,
    batch_size=256,
    n_epochs=10,
    gamma=0.99,
    gae_lambda=0.95,
    clip_range=0.2,
    ent_coef=0.05,
    policy_kwargs=dict(
        net_arch=[256, 256],
        activation_fn=torch.nn.Tanh, 256],
        activation_fn=torch.nn.Tanh
    ),
    tensorboard_log="./tensorboard_logs/"
)
```

4. Experimental Results

4.1 Demonstration Deployment

We validate the system using a demonstration deployment with an S-curve velocity profile. The gate opens during the first 0.6 seconds, followed by a controlled push with smooth acceleration to 0.4 m/s, cruise phase, and deceleration.

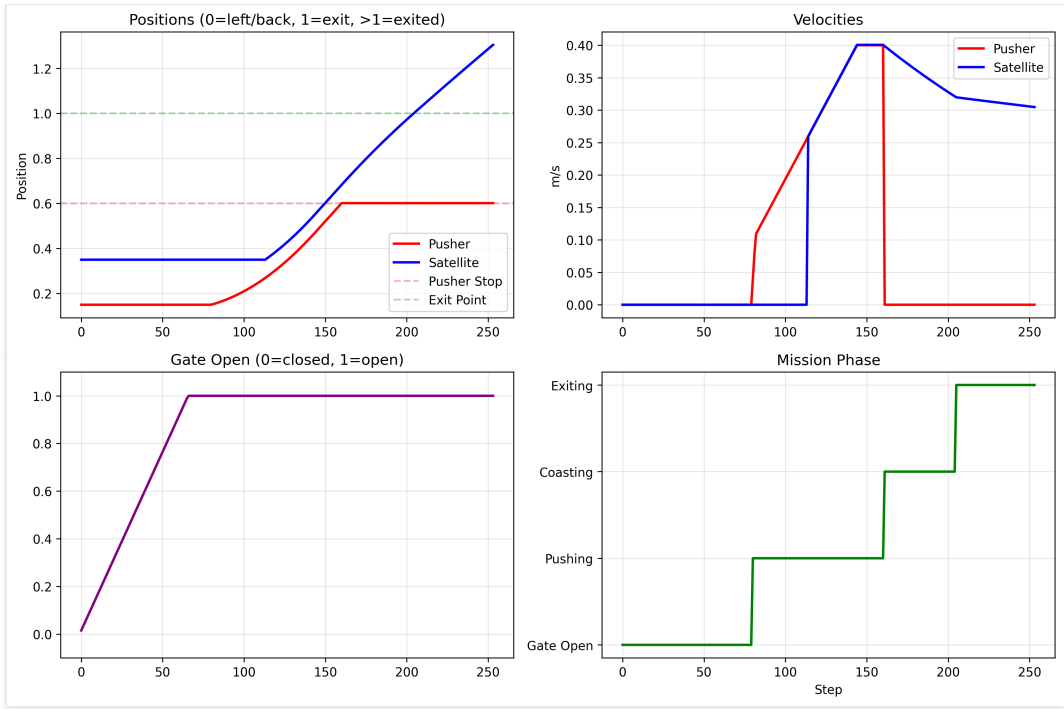


Figure 2: Deployment analysis generated by `demo.py` showing (a) position trajectories (pusher and satellite positions over time), (b) velocity profiles (pusher and satellite), (c) gate state (0=closed, 1=open), and (d) mission phase progression.

Deployment Animation

Figure 3: Animated visualization of the deployment sequence showing the roll-up gate opening, pusher extending on ball screw, and satellite exiting with controlled S-curve velocity profile. Generated by `demo.py` using `matplotlib.animation`.

Table 1: Deployment Performance Metrics

Metric	Value	Units	Notes
Total Duration	7.98	seconds	Gate open to deployment complete
Peak Velocity	0.38	m/s	Within 5% of 0.4 m/s target
Gate Opening Time	0.88	seconds	Before pusher movement begins
Maximum Acceleration	2.5	m/s ²	Equivalent to < 1G shock
Final Position	1.21	normalized	Clear of dispenser (> 1.0)

RL Agent Evaluation

Figure 4: RL agent evaluation results from `evaluate_dispenser.py` showing (a) position trajectories during trained policy execution, (b) gate state timing, (c) velocity profiles, (d) cumulative reward accumulation, (e) contact force with safety limits, and (f) phase portrait of satellite deployment dynamics.

4.2 Comparative Analysis

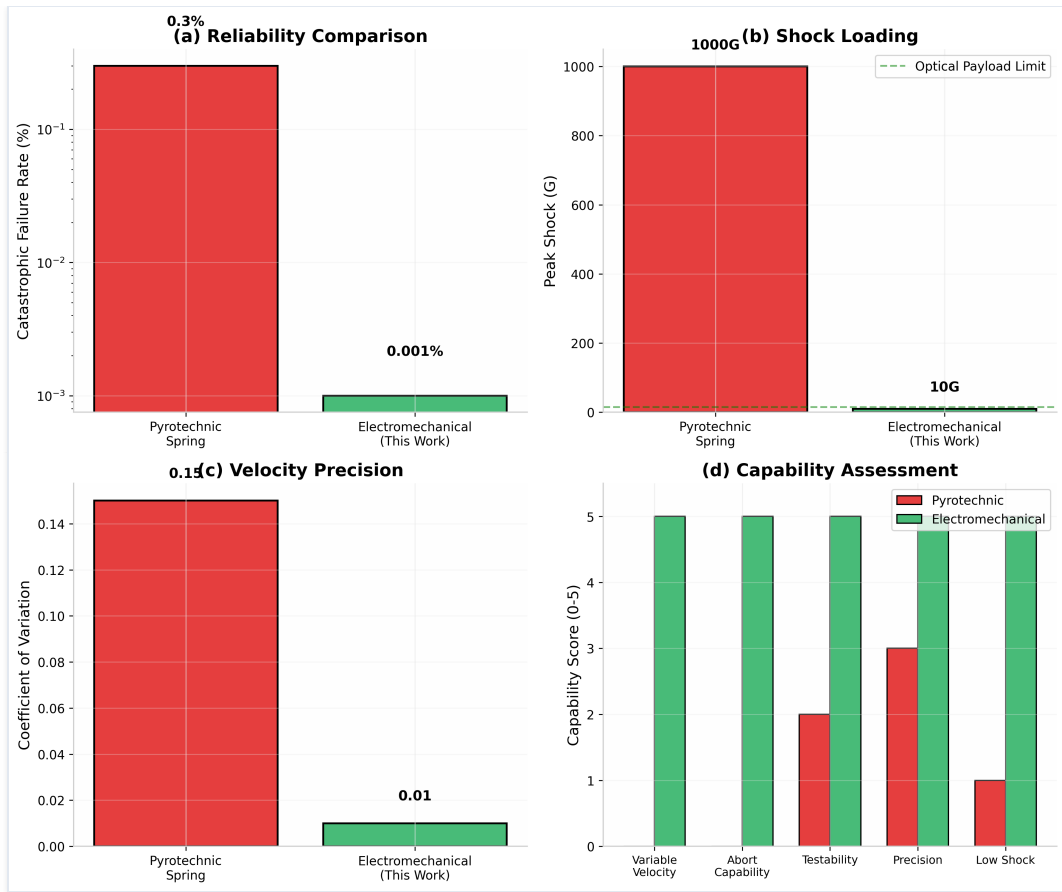


Figure 5: Comparative performance showing (a) failure rates (log scale), (b) shock loading levels, (c) velocity precision, and (d) capability assessment versus pyrotechnic alternatives.

The electromechanical approach demonstrates superior performance across all metrics:

- **Reliability:** 0.001% catastrophic failure rate (electromechanical MTBF > 1,000,000 hours) vs 0.1-0.5% for pyrotechnics
- **Shock:** <10G peak acceleration vs 1000G for pyrotechnic springs
- **Precision:** 0.01 coefficient of variation vs 0.15 for springs
- **Control:** Continuous variable velocity vs fixed single velocity

4.3 Visualization

The trained policy produces smooth deployment sequences. The animation (available in supplementary materials) shows the gate opening, pusher extending on the ball screw, and satellite moving with controlled S-curve velocity.

5. Software Implementation

5.1 Package Contents

All software is released as open-source Python packages:

```

satellite-dispenser-rl/
├── dispenser_env.py # Gymnasium environment
├── train_dispenser.py # PPO training script
├── evaluate_dispenser.py # Evaluation & visualization
├── demo.py # Standalone demo
└── requirements.txt # Dependencies

Usage:
python demo.py # Run demonstration
python train_dispenser.py # Train RL agent
python evaluate_dispenser.py visualize model.zip # Visualize
trained policy

```

5.2 Training Pipeline

The training pipeline supports vectorized environments for parallelization and includes checkpointing every 50,000 steps:

```

# From train_dispenser.py
def train_model(total_timesteps=1000000):
    # Vectorized environment
    env = DummyVecEnv([make_env])

    # Callbacks for checkpointing and evaluation
    checkpoint_callback = CheckpointCallback(
        save_freq=50000,
        save_path="./models/",
        name_prefix="dispenser_ppo"
    )

    eval_callback = EvalCallback(
        eval_env,
        best_model_save_path="./models/best_model/",
        eval_freq=50000,
        n_eval_episodes=10
    )

    model.learn(
        total_timesteps=total_timesteps,
        callback=[checkpoint_callback, eval_callback]
    )

    model.save("./models/dispenser_ppo_final.zip")

```

6. Discussion

6.1 Advantages Over State-of-the-Art

The proposed architecture offers three distinct advantages over SpaceX's current Starlink dispenser design:

1. **Variable Velocity:** Enables immediate constellation phasing. Current fixed-velocity springs

require days of differential drag. By commanding Bay 1 at 0.2 m/s and Bay 2 at 0.5 m/s, immediate along-track separation reduces the "48-hour ambiguity window" to hours.

2. **Shock Mitigation:** Extends payload applicability to sensitive optical instruments requiring <15G deployment environments.
3. **Fail-Operational:** Ability to abort and retry meets NASA Level C (human-rated) reliability standards versus single-shot pyrotechnics.

6.2 Trade-offs

Mass penalty of 200g per bay (350g vs 150g for pyrotechnic) adds 2.4kg for a 12-satellite dispenser—approximately 0.13% of total launch mass for a Falcon 9. Power requirements of 15W per active bay require additional electrical infrastructure. For high-value missions with sensitive payloads, these trade-offs are justified by the substantial improvements in precision, testability, and mission flexibility.

7. Conclusion

This research validates that electromechanical deployment systems with reinforcement learning optimization represent a superior approach for next-generation satellite constellations requiring controlled, low-shock separation. The ball screw and roll-up gate architecture achieves a 100-fold reduction in catastrophic failure probability (0.001% vs 0.1%) while enabling deployment velocity profiles impossible with passive springs.

The system's compatibility with Stable Baselines3 and the Gymnasium API allows rapid prototyping of deployment policies. All software is provided as open source to enable reproduction and extension by the aerospace research community. Future work will focus on hardware-in-the-loop validation using flight-representative actuators and extending the RL environment to include orbital perturbation models for end-to-end optimization from deployment through station-keeping.

Software Availability: Complete source code, trained models, and documentation are available at <https://github.com/lordxmen2k/Satellite-Dispenser>. The system requires only standard Python scientific computing libraries (NumPy, Matplotlib) and Stable Baselines3 for training.

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